

Field of Chaos: Reference (2026)

Prose guidance, design history, setting context, and games-mastering advice extracted from txt/jpc-rpg2.txt. Mechanical tables are collected separately in foc-just-the-rules-2026.pdf.

Introduction

The origin of this work is peer pressure, plain and simple. The Just Plain Chaos rule system existed for at least three years in nothing more than about fourteen pages. And it existed in 14 pages primarily because I just wasn't interested in additional nonsense. I wasn't interested in explaining my role-playing game philosophy or my skirmish game philosophy or my war-game philosophy. Just to have this rule system that required me to be an active participant. I never really intended for it to be played by others in a way where it was taken away from me. It was very much a rule system that was created for a very specific purpose. For a very specific genre. For something that I felt really close with, and I didn't really want to move it from that particular place.

Ultimately this peer group has forced me into this publication in some very curious way, and also in a way where the rule system can be adapted in a wide variety of different techniques. In fact, I'm going to use this book as an example to explain how what historically had been used for probably Red Army Faction-like revolutionary groups, could now be used quite comfortably for the Second World War partisan skirmish gaming with miniatures, which is really what the system became as it adapted.

Origin Story

I did want to give some degree of origin story to this thing because it has been extracted out of me, when I felt in mental weakness or other such languishing. When I was about fifteen years old, I experienced a cyber hippie commune or training camp to militarize or take already militant cyber hippies and bring them together in Australia.

It was almost like a dating club. It would have been really nice if it was a dating club. But it wasn't a dating club. It was a place where young men could get together and pontificate on what they thought the political future was going to be like. At the time, I wrote this in a book which I published in 2010 while living in the US. That had a life in and of itself. At the time of publishing in 2010, I created a role-playing game rule system associated with that particular book.

A fellow who had been an early participant in the late 1990s in Australia in the book, decided that he was going to take offense. Even though the book had been used by a variety of the other participants in a very positive light, he decided to take offense and wanted the whole thing removed from sale. This period of his mental breakdown-let's call it what it appeared to be-occurred while I was play-testing the role-playing game with my coworkers. I had actually assumed that this fellow would be a participant in some of the early games. The fully-fledged role-playing games associated with the system and through the name of this particular book, that was all coming together.

The evening of the game that was supposed to occur, he (now staying with me in the US) had some degree of breakdown which resulted in a piece of a neighbor's fence being broken, if I recall correctly. It was a very curious situation. I decided then that I was going to change the name of the original book and premise to Just Plain Chaos.

It wasn't to be based in any way on the original book and the rule system would be something that was separate. This is the origin of the rule system that you hold in your hands. This is how Just Plain Chaos actually eventuated sometime around 2018 where it was based on an old rule system and moved it forward.

Play-Testing

I play-tested it for some length of time with my coworkers. Here I need to give a thank you to all my coworkers that were participants in the early play-testing, and they really strengthened a wide variety of my particular proclivities, which I'm going to talk about more in this book. I don't know if any of them want to be explicitly named, so I'm just going to keep them anonymous in describing the introduction associated with this. Having them as play testers, a group of people that played the rules and enjoyed the rules and were able to provide cathartic play was very good for me.

Early on in the pandemic, I seem to recall, although my mind is not particularly lucid for that period of time, because I suffered the pandemic like everyone else, the rules were tested out with another group of players who very thankfully showed themselves. They were part of the podcast, that I was talking with at the time, plus a bunch of coworkers who were just looking for a video conference call periodically to play some games. They participated in that as well. So I've had multiple periods of time of actually play-testing the rule system that I'm going to provide to you, but none involved play-testing it in a World War Two scenario. I'm particularly interested in exposing this in this rule book.

It will also hopefully give you some indication, not just that this is something that can easily be shaped for your particular era of interest, usually with some degree of missile weapons that you either construct or have there previously, but maybe even you could move it into another realm, prior to heavy missile weapons, maybe just bow, arrow, swords and shields kind of weaponry. Maybe an occasional mace or cudgel. But my view is that the fluidity of the rule system is to give just enough of a taste to people that really want a rule system, but not really for those folks that want to dominate a rule system they can conquer. That's not the intention of Just Plain Chaos and as the origin story should have illustrated, it was created in just plain chaos.

Not Terrorism

The MGM shooting in Las Vegas touched me greatly because my sisters-in-law weren't there thankfully, but a number of their friends were. Historically I've created simulations of terrorism. I didn't really want a rule system that was explicitly tied to this perspective of terrorism. Distinctly different from the terrorism that was seen at the MGM or the terrorism that Islamic terrorists would perform. Probably slightly closer to militant right wing, white nationalist groups.

All these things were just not a space that I wanted to be affiliated with, even though I still had simulation work that I reused again for the Second World War. I didn't want this rule system to be just completely tarnished as only specifically used for Venezuelan radicals in the 1960s or the Red Army Faction or any of these historical groups played out in role-playing games.

That wasn't my intention. Things went cold for a period of time. In large part because I had to get my head around that I actually had a rule system that existed and needed some form. To take and go through the rigmarole of writing text for it and publishing it. On some level. Self justification or just the function of a post-COVID mind my thought was, "Let's get the rules out. Let's play with a few different genres here."

Miniatures and Probability

I don't know how far I'm going to get into the miniature gaming aspect of Just Plain Chaos, but certainly, playing it as a miniature game and a skirmish game took the rule system into a different space and not only matured it, regularized it but also simplified it drastically. The nature of having a rule system which was originally tailored for people's imaginations, but then you could point to miniatures and say that's where you are, that's what you're doing. Also, I think the resolution that people had in their own minds was probably a good thing. That changed the rule system and meant there was a lot less discussion associated with metaphysics and other various existential aspects of traditional role-playing and made it more practical. Ultimately, the aim for this rule system is that it's just a practical rule system that you can use in a pinch when you need a rule system and you need it to do certain things. The mechanics associated with battling, associated with shooting, associated with wounds, associated with all these things are things that I've actually play-tested over and over again.

I come to this with some degree of probability and some degree of computer simulation as well. I've had the ability to run some of these numbers in the game but I've also been really fascinated with how commercial outfits actually do this and I'm sure they do something similar. If they don't do it with computer simulation, they certainly have spreadsheets, that they can quickly address probabilities. I don't think these rules will contain that kind of discussion but if you want to, I'll probably add a few smatterings here and there, if you want to get a clean sense of actually what my thinking was at various times in creating this. And when discussing the historical legacy of these rules, I can't really access the early times, I've made a promise, even though it was to someone who was particularly nasty and heretical if one can use that term with regards to someone who was a former friend. But I don't particularly want to go back in time here. The nature of reminiscing-and believe me, I spent more than a decade doing it with the original rules and the original text.

Once you've had one of the members, basically, although all the members of their original writing were probably highly capable of breaking down and doing disturbing behavior, in fact, that was really just the nature of the folks involved with the original writing. My perspective is now I'm a father of two, I have a different view on the world, so I present these rules as new and as fresh as I can, without dwelling too much on the past associated with them. Aside from because it's a slightly amusing story, just presenting it here in the introduction. If you can deal with the way I presented these parameters, my hope is that you will thoroughly enjoy this rule system and I do urge you, if you feel so, please, if I'm still alive, get in contact with me and let me know what you think of these rules because that is part of the process, actually getting contact and talking about these things. I have a variety of phrases for my time in Australia, to describe elements of this thing. I think it's pretty interesting to put the stuff out there to be contacted by people that have actually enjoyed it, and that's part of the reason that I've wanted to do this experiment.

And if no one ever contacts me, no one ever contacts me.

Tom Barbalet, Las Vegas, Nevada, May 13th 2022. Games Mastery

The topic of games mastery is historically a bit of an enigma. It's an enigma for me as when I started playing role-playing games, you had the Player's Manual and the Monster Manual. You didn't have any kind of Dungeon Master's Guide. It just wasn't a necessary cost when each book was so expensive.

The Dungeon Master's Guide did exist then and after the fact I did have an opportunity to read it, but the whole nature of what the Games/Dungeon Master was in a game was so defined by a small number of experiences, which probably actually defined engaging in role-playing games in a positive light.

I've talked to people who don't have a particularly positive experience associated with role-playing games in general. It's usually because their initial games were somewhat troubled and tortured.

What I'm describing here is my own set of experiences and how to make this set of experiences as ideal as possible.

I found certainly with the advent of YouTube and putting Games Master into YouTube and getting a sense of what the Games Master style is particularly in North America, that it is a very different thing. It's part of amateur dramatics. It's quite a thespian pursuit. I don't necessarily want to satirize this by providing an introduction like this, but I did want to talk about some of the skills that I think are absolutely critical. I've certainly utilized these when playing Just Plain Chaos. So take from this what you will. The view I want to offer primarily is that you define your own course.

You have the potential to take it in whatever direction you'd like to take it in. You can completely disregard this text as being from someone of a previous generation who really hasn't experienced the heights of games mastery as you have experienced, or has not seen the heights of games mastery or you have something stylistically totally different than what I'm going to offer.

I did want to talk initially about the tone of these games. The nature of a role-playing game as it is played is that it is an event.

I've seen people play board games and war-games, and even to a lesser extent role-playing games. I typically have not participated in the circumstance where they have just a distinctly different style which lends itself from my perspective, at least to funk. I'm someone who has a very particular perspective on the tone of the environment around the way these games should be played.

The nature of people that read rules, specialize in calling out rules and looking to optimize the rules for their own game playing experience, really it all ties down, be it a board game or war-game or a role-playing game or a skirmish game or whatever the distinction is. Those that are looking to win above all costs, whatever winning might mean to them, usually aren't actually going to have the same amount of fun or be the same amount of fun to play with more importantly.

While these people might exist and culturally, certainly they exist more in certain areas than other areas. This is not something that I want to in any way advocate for. If you have someone like that in your role-playing group put to them, perhaps that this may not be actually the right venture for them to partake in, maybe organized sports, particularly in North America might be more their avenue.

Certainly I've found this particularly with regards to war-games, that the perspective of war-games, highly militarized, highly designed around winning at all costs, beating every possible opponent. These kinds of things. My perspective with role-playing, it should be a leisure activity. It should be something that actually lowers your heart rate rather than increases your heart rate. Some elements should increase your heart rate a little bit.

You are doing this for relaxation and for catharsis. If catharsis means completely trampling on your opponent, so no one has fun except for you perhaps then you're not doing the right thing.

My perspective is always that what you're trying to have is to make sure your other participants, including the games master as an independent entity, are having the best possible time that they could have. That, really has been something that I've utilized through a lot of my games be they Just Plain Chaos or any other system that I might be organizing and working around. I think it needs to be said almost explicitly that this is the history that I build from now.

There's still a whole lot of complexity that you can add in there. Certainly the distinction that I found in my childhood, particularly when I had the ability to interact with people who were clearly much better games masters than me was an ability really to hold a narrative together - quite a complicated narrative.

I learnt a lot of skills and techniques through this process, just sitting in the company of, or observing games or even actively playing games periodically. But realistically maybe three people at most through my life. I do eulogize these three people in their particular perspectives. There's always stuff to learn from other games masters.

There's always stuff to learn from how they view, play and how they construct the universes around them. For this reason I would like to offer the suggestion that this be a continued form of learning.

Let's talk a little bit about tone. I have a very strict view and I don't think this came necessarily from any particular games master but might have been explained to me once with regards to British soap operas. British soap operas are remarkably successful, I mean the American soap operas are also remarkably successful, British soap operas in particular multi-generations now of British soap operas showing that the style has worked in a very particular fashion.

When you look at any entertainment in the form of catharsis and go back to Aristotle and maybe even Plato, you start to realize that these things have been talked about from what is loosely called aesthetics, but has very little to do with visual aesthetics for quite some time.

The idea of the British soap opera is you take a character, you take a goal for the character and you put a variety of obstacles between them and their stated goal. That is something that I have utilized in games mastery through well, more explicitly, more recently because I was in England for a period of time, I must have heard about this while I was in England. But I did think about this as being an amazing way to create not necessarily a trajectory associated with actually concluding an adventure, but creating the kind of chaos that everyday life tends to give us that we have objectives that we rarely actually meet. Sometimes we actually gain those objectives.

Characters have goals. Our role in experiencing life is the number of blocks that come between us and the goals. How we overcome these particular blocks in order to achieve the goals. This is a very interesting formulaic way of creating an adventure. The way I do it in role-playing is typically you state the goal. You make the goal relative, what appears to be relatively accessible just a few days, just merely a few days in reach. And in the process of getting there, you throw these obstacles in the way of the player in such a way that they have to use their own wits and wisdom. Sometimes you can give assistance, but they have to basically work out how to get to where they're hoping to go in some way, and their imagination, a variety of other skills. The benefit of actually being a games master in the circumstances is you could see some pretty amazing narratives, some pretty amazing skills that everyday humans have other than you to resolve these issues and get them done in a particular fashion. So that really is the only games master philosophy I can give you, is consider the obstacles in front of characters, consider how they work their way around these particular obstacles. There's a big question associated with whether you artificially allow players to continue to live as well, or whether you kill them off.

Certainly when I talk to folks that have had negative role-playing game experiences, they've typically been killed off very quickly. Usually some part because of their own personality, some part because of the games master just not being at all aware of these things. There's a film called 1917 which follows two soldiers through a few days of the First World War. What's stunning about the First World War the actual war itself was a really brutal war usually involving hundreds of thousands of people. It was a war of grinding atrocities, it was really the war that I hoped humanity would learn from. I have a picture of the Somme to remind me of the Somme. And I think the First World War is just a fascinating period to realize that actually there was a more horrific war that followed it because humans didn't learn from the First World War, but let's return to the film.

The film is an amazing construction following these two particular soldiers through a series of events. Now, practically there were literally millions of soldiers on the same battlefield that they were participants in, but they really aren't there for a majority of the film. In fact, the film is absolutely extraordinary that it covers so much ground with so few actual interactions. There's a sniper in a key place, there's a crashed pilot in a key place. There's a few events which make the film very compelling watching. The musical score alone got me through COVID hands down. But the film is incredibly compelling because it's a narrative driven story with two people, normally surrounded by millions of people that you just don't see because they're not actually doing this thing. And I think it illustrates perfectly what the role of the games master is in a game that you can make it incredibly focused on two particular characters as they exist.

The film illustrated to me at an instant, what this idea of games mastery was. That you create something that people live through and experience and have to deal with problem solving and ultimately survive through. Although, I have killed a few characters occasionally, but usually for specific narrative purpose. So that's where it gets very interesting. I've historically played other games, I don't need to mention them here. But one particular game I've always played as a games master and seen the characters just get stronger and stronger and better and better and more and more experience and more and more health, and I don't necessarily want to give away what the game is, but this has always been really difficult. So in that case, I've had Orcs for example, which might exist in a just blank game that you create, so much the better. And I've moved these Orcs from everyday kind of the mill newborn, wearing leather armor Orcs to increasingly militarized Orcs. I did the same with dwarves actually in parallel in this game, to give them the assistance of dwarves at various military levels, where they had the enemies of Orcs at various military levels that progressively militarized and got bigger and badder and nastier and harder to fight.

There was always a constant. It would take about 30 minutes to an hour to fight a bunch of Orcs? Yes. Whether they were at the start of the game or the middle of the game or the end of the game. And this was an 18-month plus roughly weekly game. You have to be mindful of

these things that the nature of the Combatants, the nature of the players. These things all need to be relatively, roughly aligned. Obviously there are more difficult characters in this particular game, again, not just playing chaos, but illustrative here. Dragons occurred at various points and they were various kinds. And particularly with regards to the telepathy and control and a variety of other factors. The dragons were very much sized to be roughly seven times more powerful than the humans or the creatures that they were fighting with the players. So these kinds of obstacles, and also having non-player characters that would mysteriously get fire blasted at some points and survive in some cases and not survive in others. A good idea of statistics, a good idea of dice roll, a good idea of probability and also a good idea of your players. This is developed over time.

In coming to this as a middle-aged man offering this suggestion to you, please understand that this is not designed for some 10 year old kid that might have just picked up this book because they're reading inappropriate things at this stage. My view is these are learnt experiences that happen over long periods of time. And sadly, I've not had a lot of gaming in my life. Personally, I've come to it at spits and spurts where it's been available to me, where people have said, "I've never played these games before." And I've been able to illustrate to them what these game experiences are like and then my life goes on unfortunately. My aim in some regard, and I've been given this aim by people that I've met and talked with is to find local groups that might be sympathetic to my particular vision, which has been very difficult through variety of migration and other experiences, which I'll just leave right here.

What I wanted to illustrate through this text is the diversity of perspective that you need to have, and that you come to this through life experiences, which ideally, hopefully you've played as games or you've played in your head, or you've worked out to some degree of parameters, that when you test out on living, breathing other human beings, you are at least at the basic level of competency in order to, if you do accidentally kill off a few characters, still have a few characters that are left to play. Or you have instances where players get sick of characters and want new characters. And you're like, ah! A perfect opportunity for them to go on some very dangerous adventure. But in the scheme of these things, I also want there are a few films which are good examples, I think certainly 1917 is the most recent one.

There were certainly periods of time in the 1980s, which you might go back and look on reflectively as very curious, where a lot of this stuff was perceived. A lot of role-playing was perceived as being demonic. And I do understand now that acting in various other thespian pursuits that nerds might have once engaged with have washed over this and made this more an acting pursuit than it was. You know, understanding a lot about mythological creatures and these kinds of things. But I really implore you to actually go and do some background research on mythological creatures and find early books and get a sense of where this thing has evolved from. Because it's certainly... As I look at my bookshelf now, this is illustrative of a majority of the books that I own. And also, just my general consumption of information is really much in this historical realm. The new ones are interesting. It was funny to play a contemporary role-playing game with a group of coworkers, just to get a sense of where these things have come. But a lot of the grit and a lot of the majesty exists in the early history of it. And I think I've probably said enough by this point.

Hiding and Explicit Movement (with Documents)

The adventure can be many different factors. Yet a lot of what's being described here relates to stealth and hiding. Constant hiding, always hiding, always finding the next place to hide. Living openly is not a large portion of this game and certainly if the characters find themselves in a hiding role, they must know both where they are currently and where they're going. They must have some sense of the secrecy associated with these locations.

When you play a game where things are under surveillance - you have a permission to move or you have a permission to stay in place. You require some documents which you have to carry with you, and these are things that should be pointed out strongly to players. They need to make sure the documents are in order particularly if they want to move between locations.

There's an idea of deep hiding where you don't have any documents and you're just looking to evade capture in all circumstances, to a point of just general hiding where you maintain some documents that you might need that obviously draw attention away from you as a person of interest. You need to be very mindful both for the player and the games master in these kinds of circumstances.

The role of weapons in these games is relatively minor, and actually when the player gathers weapons or gets explosives, or obtains some means to defend themselves, their behavior is going to change from explicit hiding, but there's always a notion in most of these games that a majority of the population will turn against you. Some portion of the population is armed and better armed than you are.

The acquiring of weapons and the acquiring of safe documents - the acquiring of passage - and the acquiring of safe location. These are all things that the player should be incredibly mindful of. Most players don't come to this kind of game with any background. Their knowledge of how to acquire documents and safety and forging documents, these things that had to be done at various times, at various locations, and eras in which these games are set.

The games master has to be relatively helpful to point out if they are moving in the open, what kind of documents they have with them. If they don't have any documents, then the acquiring of documents or the forging of documents is absolutely critical and should be a primary part of the game.

Certainly the acquisition of weapons could be a primary part of the game. The player has to find weapons, find documents, find means of movement and either then sell this information or sell these weapons, where you hide weapons. I don't want to write about this at great length. This is the player's imagination and the games master's imagination. Oftentimes the players will have a greater imagination than the games master will have in these circumstances.

The idea is just framing that the players need to keep themselves covert or need to have a certain amount of either false or stolen documentation that enables them to move. Actual documented movement is very interesting. If the player was of a group that wouldn't be persecuted in the area, but would still have to have some movement documents, they would need to go and acquire the movement documents. Either through the police or other mechanisms of obtaining these documents. The procuring of the documents could be in a variety of ways, it might just be a legal fee, or it might require some quid pro quo or some behavior that the player needs to exert in order to get the documents that they need to move. The acquiring of things like weapons is far more difficult than that of documents. Movement documents or existence documents have some ease of procurement because of the nature of getting this kind of information in these kinds of environments.

If you're playing a Second World War under occupation game. There is a great discrepancy between the kinds of occupation that existed in certain areas and the kinds of occupation that existed in the other areas, and this is really down to the games master how they want to play it. When the players procure weapons and how they use the weapons, it's also a relatively dangerous process. The weapons make noise, and noise gathers interest. The way in which the players use weapons, some weapons are intentionally silenced, but that still doesn't mean that they're absolutely whisper-quiet. That just means they don't make as much noise as the weapons that are not silenced.

It's important to measure all of this, and as a games master really plan this out in your own thinking associated with the areas that the players are in. The rules and procedures are in place. There are certain areas, particularly areas of no cities, forest, rural areas which are completely and utterly off limits.

You need to think about the areas that surround the towns and the cities that the players are playing. The rules that exist in these areas and whether stealth is important in movement in certain parts and less so in other parts. If the player was to move on roads, they're going to be stopped and searched or they are still going to be stopped and asked for documents in certain circumstances.

There is still a constant threat of interaction, which they need to be mindful of as they make their way in any specific direction. The role that maps can play in these games is important. It's important for the players to make their own maps. You can explain as the games master to the players what things look like and what the kind of environment that they're in. You will need to retain maps.

It is a point of style, whether you maintain physical maps or whether you read up in advance and memorize roughly where the locations are and where the players are moving through locations.

This author rarely used physical maps, because they were a distraction. They were also documents that could easily be seen by players in certain circumstances. If you work with semi-hostile players, which you should never actually have to do, the addition of maps and the addition of where these things were and what was going on, the physicality of the maps were a problem. So in general, I would read extensively beforehand and memorize routes and memorize examples, and where possible, if I was using miniatures, show the miniatures... Show the environment with the miniatures. And when I wasn't using miniatures, I had to be incredibly descriptive in certain circumstances, so the players actually understood where they were and where they were going.

And you can talk about locations in ideas terms, but when you actually have to physically move to that location, this requires a good degree of descriptive examples, as you explain to the players what they're doing. Now, ideally the players will have movement goals, which means you're just describing the movement from first movement goal to second movement goal, which is oftentimes the easiest way to do this. But sometimes the players just don't have a sense of the environment and you have to actively describe the environment and do it in such a way where you're allowing the players to understand, particularly if they're moving in stealth, that there are aspects of the environment that might change rapidly, the sound aspect of the environment is incredibly critical. So the movement and the hearing of boots or the hearing of a gun loading or all these kinds of things are sounds which the players will be very receptive to if they're trying to move in stealth.

So it's the games master's role to think about these things in advance. Think about the sounds that happen, with the various kinds of uniforms and movement, the sounds that happen with the players. Whether the players are barefoot or have cloth and shoes, or what mechanisms the players are using for stealth. And this is a descriptive thing as well, where players need to actively describe, where we are, moving in such

ways to make minimal possible noise. Well, that ultimately slows down movement considerably. So the players are moving slowly, they're trying not to make noise. But there are additional accoutrements that they might have, they might have a pack or something that contains items that make noise, a pack that contains metal items that might clang together, all these kinds of things. All these descriptive elements are just painting a picture for the players in their own minds, and the games master is a central component in this.

So the games master needs to be very mindful of sound, he should be very mindful if their players are moving through darkened environments associated with any form of lighting, or anything which could create light in the circumstance. So you need to be very mindful of the environment and mindful of things around the environment, and mindful of what is potential to go on in the environment. As a rule of thumb, I will generally roll dice almost continuously through doing my games mastering, and that's something that I do sometimes for my own ideas of probability. I'm like, "Well, what's the probability of this thing happening? Well, it's going to take this dice roll." Most of that, rather than relying on a book or paper work or something to get a sense of what the probability is, is also done in my head. This is part of the games mastering that I like to do, is have a very minimal paper element but maximize the rolling of dice, maximize the suspense aspect to this thing.

And do so in a way where the players are almost constantly feeling on edge, or constantly feeling like something might be happening, or I'm rolling dice for some particular reason. Sometimes I don't even roll dice for a particular reason, I just roll a die, you're just rolling dice. You just make sure that you meter, in a minute or so you might roll the dice four or five times. You occasionally spend a little bit of time picking out dice, you're picking out different sides of the dice and you put them together, and you roll them. And sometimes that is theater, and sometimes that is reality. Sometimes it has absolutely no bearing whatsoever, and another time you're working on a specific probability of which maybe a D6, a D8 or a D12 would be perfectly suited, and you reach for that die and you roll it accordingly. And this is really part of the underlying element of the games master, the games master banter through the movement and through the general description.

So you have these environments, you have the potential for enemies entering these environments, you have the need for paperwork and other things which you've drilled into the players. And then you just allow the game to evolve. Most games can exist almost all in just movement and storytelling. The actual combat element, if you look at the video games industry, which is a perfect example of how to weave these kinds of tales, you have lots and lots of suspense, lots of movement and then finally, a little bit of gameplay. And I think role-playing is very similar, so it's the same kind of notion that you're creating an environment, mainly psychological, mainly in the minds of the players. And it's your role to make sure that things like... If they're moving stealthily, this has to take continued rolls and continued affirmation. And sometimes you get players to roll. This is another important point. You're rolling dice, the players are periodically rolling dice.

Rarely might you tell a player what they're doing with the dice roll, but sometimes you might for effect. You just ask them to roll a D4 or roll two D10, and roll a D20, what do you get? You do this periodically, and the purpose for GM-ing where they say, you need to roll a D20, or you need to get above your dexterity or something like that. These are all old hat things, another time gone by. It's nice for the games masters to believe that the players should always have preemptive knowledge of the circumstances that are occurring. And my view is, specifically for these kinds of games, you'll never run out of circumstance. So if you like the idea of giving a narrative to the player that they're rolling dice for specific things, there's plenty of time to do that in general play, but through normal play, just ask them to roll the dice periodically. And maybe that fits into your percentages or your probabilities that you're thinking about as a games master. Sometimes you might want to give them specific reasons that they're rolling dice, but a lot of times just ask them to roll a die. It adds to the cadence of the gameplay.

Narrative Guidance

Consider the purpose of the experience of playing Just Plain Chaos to explore a rich universe and develop your character (or your players) through this experience. Rather than creating life and death circumstances at every turn of the game, consider the development of scenarios in the game as being a means of choosing distinct character paths and also exploring the particularly twisted and complex universe. There are, however, a wide variety of conditions other than death that can end the game. The loss of a character's physical and/or mental mobility may cause the game to end. Capture and/or imprisonment may leave the character in an immobile state. Although either case could also be used as the starting point of another scenario. Consider the narrative flow the most important element of the game. At the time of writing there is only one work available to review the style of narrative used in Just Plain Chaos however this rule book will also provide a number of techniques and background examples to assist with creating a detailed narrative both as a Player and a Controller.

Setting History And General Notes

Early 1990s - A small armed insurrection occurs. In the process of squashing the insurrection a substantial number of civilians are killed. This ferments a revolutionary spirit in a majority of the population. This divides the population based on social classes with the wealthy and the quisling middle-class forming their own communities.

Late 1990s - In cracking down on the majority, walled and militarized settlements are created in existing cities. These environments are specially policed and controlled. Economic wealth flows to those elite areas while the majority of the population are forced into high-rise apartment towers.

1999 - Led by a small group of youthful leaders, the majority population attempt a revolution against the ruling elite. This includes the use of dirty bomb technology and ultimately leaves a majority of the environment in ruin following excessive bombing of the majority population.

2003 - Following a brief lull in the fighting and an observed truce, the ruling elite attempts a mass extermination program forcing the majority population into labor camps leaving the created cities virtually deserted. Armed insurrection follows.

Mid-2000s - The fighting continues. For the majority, all economic resources dry up. The majority are left to fend for themselves through the huge crumbling cities that are left. Some try creating agricultural communes as a means of growing food however these fail and mass starvation further reduces the majority population.

2012 - A truce is declared as a means of further concentrating the majority and eradicating them. Small groups of the majority continue to hide in the ruined cities and form roving revolutionary gangs dressed in the clothes of their parents' last factory jobs.

Mid-2010s - Increasingly cultist, the ruling class begins a series of experiments to try to create a sub-human species including attempts at resurrection and various other strange experiments.

General Notes

Technology has been stifled through years of war. The internet does not exist however a cultist mythology around modem connected networks (known as the Wazarin) forms the basis for any electronic communication. History prior to the 1990s is conveyed through mythology.

The history outlined above is a limited overview designed to give a player a basic understanding of what their Character knows.

There are two languages available - Majority and Elite.

Why You Won't See World War Two Rules From Me

We now enter a very curious part of the book. This was originally going to be an example of how you play the Second World War from a partisan skirmish perspective with the languages and the weapon skills and the forging of documents and all the other bits and pieces. It happened in parallel with me changing from a simulation development that I've worked on for a couple of years relating to Operation Sea Lion in England. Through that process, I generated substantial German documentation, including information like the specific documents, the actual bureaucracy, that turned the Hitler Youth into the Waffen-SS, which was incredibly graphic and left me without a doubt that this was just not represented. The German Second World War experience was not represented in any form that I could actively describe to a player or a games master in order to play. The nature of the films and the material that is available. The histories didn't give the gravitas to the nature of just the layered bureaucracy, which made everything feel very calm and kosher, but actually, relied on the execution of German children.

It was a very curious experience to me, which actually took a few months following the movement away from simulating Operation Sea Lion to fully dwell upon. I don't want to embody any aspect of the Second World War German invasion plans or thinking. The failure to describe it in both literature and film was by far the most shocking experience for me because I had historically recommended films like Das Boot. And similarly, there were a couple of films associated with the end of Hitler's life, Downfall being one of the more famous ones with actual German origin. A lot of the German origin stuff still fails to capture just the layered detail. And in order to discuss how games mastery was incredibly important and people needed to play these games properly, I didn't have a way to capture the nature of both invasion, but also the scheming and the development and just the evil bureaucracy that came after that. It was outside my realm as a games master. I'm in this strange situation where having planned a little bit of, here are these weapons, here are these people, here's the situation, here's this possibility, I felt it was unjust to offer this as any kind of example about how to play this rule system.

I'm returning quite quickly to the notion that this really should be used in the context of near earth science fiction, not in any way associated with historical events, not in any way associated with what happened in Germany following the Second World War, specifically, the Red Army Faction or Baader-Meinhof. Nothing like that. I think all that should just be removed quite comfortably, and put on a side where really the gravitas of not actually having adequate documentation associated with that, I find incredibly powerful and incredibly revealing, but also it comes through the nature of actually handling these documents and getting a sense that real people created them. And the execution of

what happened in the Holocaust is bad enough, but the nature of what happened in the state towards the end of the fall of the Third Reich, the downfall period, is just behaviors which I don't even know how to embody in a contemporary fashion.

They just struck me as incredibly toxic and not something that I want to be a part of. The promise of having a Second World War partisan intrigue game being built off these rules, I'll move to one side. But I did want to say that these rules are incredibly flexible and it wouldn't be difficult to do that, I just don't think you could honestly do it to the depth of depravity that was necessary and not in a playable game that you were looking to get any form of catharsis out. So now I've stated that explicitly, I will go on to say that, yes, it would be relatively easy to have these rules in a Baader-Meinhof, Red Army Faction game or post that potentially, what happened in the Munich Olympics, you could do all of these things, but I don't find any of that particularly edifying.

I think this is a futuristic game with character development and shootouts. Yes, the rules are there, they should be relatively adequate to play in that fashion. And for that reason, I'm going to give the rules as is with some slight bridging, to talk a little bit about skills and development, and how to utilize the difficulty in layering skills that you need to get certain abstract skills and not others, and then you need to work out how you fit your characters together. Describing that would enable a GM quite comfortably to play a wide variety of games, but I did feel the need to, spit the dummy as they used to say in Australia with regards to getting this rule system out on a partisan World War Two basis.

I just do not feel the ability to develop it in an authentic fashion, more over, I think it's incredibly important that people are mindful of the fact that these pieces of fiction, these films, even the documentaries about the Second World War are not as accurate and as depraved as you would actually need to play games in order to make it. So I will put this footnote in now, as a former attempted simulator of Sea Lion, that this is not a direction that I'd like to take. So the rules will be developed very similar to the rules as they're outlined. And please be mindful if you do want to do this experimentation that is perfectly available in the rule system, I just don't think you'll get much edifying out of it. So I wanted to leave that right here and put it out.